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Coming Together: The Asian American Movement

Arriving in the United States, nineteenth-century immigrants from Asian countries did not think of themselves as "Asians." Coming from specific districts in provinces in different nations, Asian immigrant groups did not even consider themselves Chinese, Japanese, Korean, and so forth, but rather people from Toisan, Hoiping, or some other district in Guandong Province in China or from Hiroshima, Yamaguchi, or some other prefecture in Japan. Members of each group considered themselves culturally and politically distinct. Historical enmities between their mother countries further separated the groups even after their arrival in the United States. Writing about early Asian immigrant communities, Eliot Mears (1928:4) reported that "it is exceptional when one learns of any entente between these Orientals." However, non-Asians had little understanding or appreciation of these distinctions. For the most part, outsiders accorded to Asian peoples certain common characteristics and traits that were essentially supranational (Browne 1985: 8–9). Indeed, the exclusion acts and quotas limiting Asian immigration to the United States relied upon racist constructions of Asians as homogeneous (Lowe 1991: 28).

Mindful that whites generally lump all Asians together, early Asian immigrant communities sought to "keep their images discrete

and were not above denigrating, or at least approving the denigration of, other Asian groups" (Daniels 1988: 113). It was not until the late 1960s, with the advent of the Asian American movement, that a pan-Asian consciousness and constituency were first formed. To build political unity, college students of Asian ancestry heralded their common fate—the similarity of experiences and treatment that Asian groups endured in the United States (Omi and Winant 1986: 105). In other words, the pan-Asian concept, originally imposed by non-Asians, became a symbol of pride and a rallying point for mass mobilization by later generations. This chapter examines the social, political, and demographic factors that allowed pan-Asianism to take root in the 1960s and not earlier.

Ethnic "Disidentification"

Before the 1960s, Asians in this country frequently practiced ethnic disidentification, the act of distancing one's group from another group so as not to be mistaken and suffer the blame for the presumed misdeeds of that group (Hayano 1981: 162). Faced with external threats, group members can either intensify their solidarity or they can distance themselves from the stigmatized segment. Instead of uniting to fight anti-Asian forces, early Asian immigrant communities often disassociated themselves from the targeted group so as not to be mistaken for members of it and suffer any possible negative consequences (Hayano 1981: 161; Daniels 1988: 113). Two examples of ethnic disidentification among Asians in this country occurred during the various anti-Asian exclusion movements and during World War II. These incidents are instructive not only as evidence of ethnic disidentification but also as documentation of the pervasiveness of racial lumping. Precisely because of racial lumping, persons of Asian ancestry found it necessary to disassociate themselves from other Asian groups.

Exclusion Movements

Beginning with the first student laborers in the late nineteenth century, Japanese immigrants always differentiated themselves from Chinese immigrants. Almost uniformly, Japanese immi-

grants perceived their Chinese counterparts in an "unsympathetic, negative light, and often repeated harsh American criticisms of the Chinese" (Ichioka 1988: 191). In their opinion, the Chinese came from an inferior nation; they also were lower-class laborers, who had not adapted themselves to American society. In 1892, a Japanese student laborer described San Francisco's Chinatown as "a world of beasts in which . . . exists every imaginable depravity, crime, and vice" (cited in Ichioka 1988: 191).

Indeed, the Japanese immigrants were a more select group than their Chinese counterparts. The Japanese government viewed overseas Japanese as representatives of their homeland. Therefore, it screened prospective emigrants to ensure that they were healthy and literate and would uphold Japan's national honor (Takaki 1989: 46).

More important, Japanese immigrants distanced themselves from the Chinese because they feared that Americans would lump them together. Aware of Chinese exclusion, Japanese immigrant leaders had always dreaded the thought of Japanese exclusion. To counteract any negative association, Japanese immigrant leaders did everything possible to distinguish themselves from the Chinese immigrants (Ichioka 1988: 250). For example, to separate themselves from the unassimilable Chinese laborers, some Japanese immigrant leaders insisted that their Japanese workers wear American work clothes and even eat American food (Ichioka 1988: 185). In 1901, the Japanese in California distributed leaflets requesting that they be differentiated from the Chinese (tenBroek, Barnhart, and Matson 1970: 23).

However, under the general rubric Asiatic, the Japanese inherited the painful experiences of the Chinese.¹ All the vices attributed to the Chinese were transferred to these newest Asian immigrants (Browne 1985). Having successfully excluded Chinese laborers, organized labor once again led the campaign to drive out the Japanese immigrants. In 1904, the American Federation of Labor adopted its first anti-Japanese resolution. Charging that the Japanese immigrants were as undesirable as the Chinese, the unions' resolution called for the expansion of the 1902 Chinese Exclusion Act to include Japanese and other Asian laborers. By mid-1905, the labor unions of California had joined forces to establish the Asiatic Exclusion League (Hill 1973: 52–54; Ichioka 1988: 191–192).

Since the Japanese immigrants considered themselves superior to the Chinese, they felt indignant and insulted whenever they were

lumped together with them. In 1892, a Japanese immigrant wrote in the *Oakland Enquirer* that he wished "to inveigh with all my power" against American newspapers that compared the Japanese to "the truly ignorant class of Chinese laborers and condemned them as bearers of some mischievous Oriental evils" (cited in Ichioka 1988: 192). Instead of joining with the Chinese to fight the anti-Asian exclusion movement, some Japanese leaders went so far as to condone publicly the exclusion of the Chinese while insisting that the Japanese were the equals of Americans (Daniels 1988: 113). Above all else, Japanese immigrant leaders wanted Japanese immigration to be treated on the same footing as European immigration (Ichioka 1988: 250).

In the end, Japanese attempts at disidentification failed. With the passage of the 1924 Immigration Act, Japanese immigration was effectively halted. This act contained two provisions designed to stop Japanese immigration. The first barred the immigration of Japanese wives even if their husbands were United States citizens. The second prohibited the immigration of aliens ineligible for citizenship. Because the Supreme Court had ruled in 1922 that persons of Japanese ancestry could not become naturalized citizens, this provision effectively closed the door on Japanese and most other Asian immigration (U.S. Commission on Civil Rights 1986: 8–9). The Japanese immigrants felt doubly affronted by the 1924 act because it ranked them, not as the equals of Europeans, but on the same level as the lowly Chinese, the very people whom they themselves considered inferior (Ichioka 1988: 250). Thus, despite all their attempts to disassociate themselves from the Chinese, with the passage of the act, the Japanese joined the Chinese as a people deemed unworthy of becoming Americans. Little did they foresee that, in less than two decades, other Asian groups in America would disassociate themselves from the Japanese.

World War II and Japanese Internment

Immediately after the bombing of Pearl Harbor, the incarceration of Japanese Americans began. On the night of December 7, the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) began taking into custody persons of Japanese ancestry who had connections to the Japanese government. Working on the principle of guilt by associa-

tion, the security agencies simply rounded up most of the Issei (first-generation) leaders of the Japanese community. Initially, the federal government differentiated between alien and citizen Japanese Americans, but this distinction gradually disappeared. In the end, the government evacuated more than 100,000 persons of Japanese ancestry into concentration camps, approximately two-thirds of whom were American-born citizens. It was during this period that the Japanese community discovered that the legal distinction between citizen and alien was not nearly so important as the distinction between white and yellow (Daniels 1988: ch. 6).

Like the Japanese, the Chinese understood the importance of the distinction between white and yellow. Fearful that they would be targets of anti-Japanese activities, many persons of Chinese ancestry, especially in the West, took to wearing buttons that proclaimed positively "I'm Chinese." Similarly, many Chinese shopkeepers displayed signs announcing, "This is a Chinese shop." Some Chinese immigrants even joined the white persecution with buttons that added "I hate Japs worse than you do" (Daniels 1988: 205; Takaki 1989: 370–371). The small Korean and Filipino communities took similar actions. Because of Japan's occupation of Korea at the time, being mistaken as Japanese particularly angered Koreans in the United States. Cognizant of Asian lumping, the United Korean Committee prepared identification cards proclaiming "I am Korean." During the early months of the war, women wore Korean dresses regularly to distinguish themselves from the Japanese (Melendy 1977: 158; Takaki 1989: 365–366). Similarly, persons of Filipino ancestry wore buttons proclaiming "I am a Filipino" (Takaki 1989: 363).

Given the wars between their mother countries and Japan, it is not surprising that the Chinese, Koreans, and Filipinos distanced themselves from the Japanese. But their reactions are instructive not only as examples of ethnic disidentification but also as testimonies to the pervasiveness of racial lumping. Popular confusion of the various Asian groups was so prevalent that it was necessary for Chinese, Filipinos, and Koreans to don ethnic clothing and identification buttons to differentiate themselves from the Japanese. Without these *visible* signs of ethnicity, these three Asian groups would probably have been mistaken for Japanese by anti-Japanese forces. As Ronald Takaki (1989: 370) reported, Asian groups "remembered how they had previously been called 'Japs' and how many whites had lumped all Asians

together." But there are also examples of how Asian groups united when inter-Asian cooperation advanced their common interests.

Inter-Asian Labor Movements

The most notable example of inter-Asian solidarity was the 1920 collaboration of Japanese and Filipino plantation laborers in Hawaii. In the beginning, plantation workers had organized in terms of national origins. Thus, the Japanese belonged to the Japanese union and the Filipinos to the Filipino union. In the early 1900s, an ethnically based strike seemed sensible to Japanese plantation laborers because they represented about 70 percent of the entire work force. Filipinos constituted less than 1 percent. However, by 1920, Japanese workers represented only 44 percent of the labor force, while Filipino workers represented 30 percent. Japanese and Filipino union leaders understood that they would have to combine to be politically and economically effective (Johanessen 1950: 75–83; Takaki 1989: 152).

Because together they constituted more than 70 percent of the work force in Oahu, the 1920 Japanese–Filipino strike brought plantation operations to a sudden stop. Although the workers were eventually defeated, the 1920 strike was the “first major interethnic working-class struggle in Hawaii” (Takaki 1989: 154).² Subsequently, the Japanese Federation of Labor elected to become an interethnic union. To promote a multiethnic class solidarity, the new union called itself the Hawaii Laborers Association (Takaki 1989: 154–155).

Although the 1920 strike was a *de facto* example of pan-Asian cooperation, this cooperation needs to be distinguished from the post-1960 pan-Asian solidarity. The purported unifying factor in 1920 was a common class status, not a shared cultural or racial background (Takaki 1989: 154). This class solidarity is different from the large-scale organization of ethnicity that emerged in the late 1960s. For most Asian Americans, the more recent development represents an enlargement of their identity system, a circle beyond their previous national markers of identity. True, like working-class unions, pan-ethnic groups are interest groups with material demands (Glazer and Moynihan 1963; Bonacich and Modell 1980). However, unlike labor unions, panethnic groups couch their demands in ethnic or racial terms—not purely in class terms. In other words, their ethnicity is

used as a basis for the assertion of collective claims, many but not all of which are class based.

Social and Demographic Changes: Setting the Context

Although Asians in the United States have long been engaged in political action, their efforts never drew public attention until the 1960s (Chan 1991: 171). Prompted by broader political struggles and internal demographic changes, college students of Asian ancestry spearheaded the Asian American movement. Critical to its development was the mobilization of American blacks. Besides offering tactical lessons, the civil rights and the Black Power movements had a profound impact on the consciousness of Asian Americans, sensitizing them to racial issues (Uyematsu 1971). The anticolonial nationalist movements in Asia also stirred racial and cultural pride and provided a context for the emergence of the Yellow Power movement (P. Wong 1972). Influenced by these broader political struggles, Americans of Asian ancestry united to denounce racist institutional structures, demand new or unattended rights, and assert their cultural and racial distinctiveness. Normal urban issues such as housing, education, and social welfare began to take on ethnic coloration.

While important, these broader societal developments alone do not explain why the Asian American movement became panethnic. To understand this development, we first need to understand the underlying social and demographic factors that allowed pan-Asianism to take root in the 1960s but not earlier. Before World War II, pan-Asian unity was not feasible because the predominantly foreign-born Asian population did not share a common language. During the postwar years, increasing intergroup communication and contact facilitated the emergence of a pan-Asian consciousness. The breakdown of economic and residential barriers during the postwar period provided the first opportunity for an unprecedented number of Asian Americans to come into intimate, sustained contact with the larger society—and with one another.

TABLE 2.1

Chinese and Japanese American Foreign-Born Population in the United States, 1860–1940

Year	Chinese		Japanese	
	Number	Percentage Foreign-Born	Number	Percentage Foreign-Born
1900	80,853	90	24,057	99
1910	56,596	79	67,655	94
1920	43,107	70	81,383	73
1930	44,086	59	70,477	51
1940	37,242	48	47,305	37

Source. U.S. Bureau of the Census (1943: tables 4 and 6).

From an Immigrant to a Native Population

Before 1940, the Asian population in the United States was primarily an immigrant population (see Table 2.1). Immigrant Asians faced practical barriers to pan-Asian unity. Foremost was their lack of a common language. Old national rivalries were another obstacle, as many early Asian immigrants carried the political memories and outlook of their homelands. For example, Japan's occupation of Korea resulted in pervasive anti-Japanese sentiments among Koreans in the United States. According to Brett Melendy (1977: 155), "Fear and hatred of the Japanese appeared to be the only unifying force among the various Korean groups through the years." Moreover, these historical enmities and linguistic and cultural differences reinforced one another as divisive agents.

During the postwar period, due to immigration restrictions and the growing dominance of the second and third generations, American-born Asians outnumbered immigrants. The demographic changes of the 1940s were pronounced. During this decade, nearly twenty thousand Chinese American babies were born. For the first time, the largest five-year cohort of Chinese Americans was under five years of age (Kitano and Daniels 1988: 37). By 1960, approximately two-thirds of the Asian population in California had been born in

the United States (Ong 1989: 5–8). As the Asian population became a native-born community, linguistic and cultural differences began to blur. Although they had attended Asian-language schools, most American-born Asians possessed only a limited knowledge of their ethnic language (Chan 1991: 115). By 1960, with English as the common language, persons from different Asian backgrounds were able to communicate with one another (Ling 1984: 73), and in so doing create a common identity associated with the United States.

Moreover, unlike their immigrant parents, native-born and American-educated Asians could muster only scant loyalties to old world ties. Historical antagonisms between their mother countries thus receded in importance (P. Wong 1972: 34). For example, growing up in America, second-generation Koreans “had difficulty feeling the painful loss of the homeland and understanding the indignity of Japanese domination” (Takaki 1989: 292). Thus, while the older generation of Koreans hated all Japanese, “their children were much less hostile or had no concern at all” (Melendy 1977: 156). As a native-born Japanese American community advocate explained, “By 1968, we had a second generation. We could speak English; so there was no language problem. And we had little feelings of historical animosity” (Kokubun interview).

As national differences receded in subjective importance, generational differences widened. For the most part, American-born Asians considered themselves to have more in common with other American-born Asians than they did with foreign-born compatriots.³ According to a third-generation Japanese American who is married to a Chinese American, “As far as our experiences in America, I have more things in common than differences with a Chinese American. Being born and raised here gives us something in common. We have more in common with each other than with a Japanese from Japan, or a Chinese from China” (Ichioka interview). Much to their parents’ dismay, young Asian Americans began to choose their friends and spouses from other Asian groups. Eui-Young Yu (1983: 47) related that second- and third-generation Koreans “identify and intermingle as much with other Asian minorities as with fellow Koreans, especially with the Japanese and Chinese.” Similarly, Stephen Fugita and David O’Brien (1991: 146) reported that the Sansei (third-generation) were much more likely than the Nisei (second-generation) to see themselves as Asian Americans. This muting of cultural and histori-

cal divisions distressed their parents, who, more often than not, had supported these divisions for most of their lives. As a young Chinese American asserted:

My parents mean well and I try to respect them, but they do not understand what it's all about. We have buried the old hatreds between Chinese and Japanese, and my friends and I must go beyond our parents' "hang-ups." My mother is upset because I'm engaged to a Japanese girl but she knows she can do nothing about it. (Cited in Weiss 1974: 235)

The Watershed of World War II

Before World War II, Asian immigrant communities were quite distinct entities, isolated from one another and from the larger society. Because of language difficulties, prejudice, and lack of business opportunities elsewhere, there was little chance for Asians in the United States to live outside their ethnic enclaves (Yuan 1966: 331). Shut out of the mainstream of American society, the various immigrant groups struggled separately in their respective Chinatowns, Little Tokyos, or Manilatowns. Stanford Lyman (1970: 57–63) reported that the early Chinese and Japanese communities in the western states had little to do with one another—either socially or politically. Although statistical data do not exist, ethnographic accounts confirm the ethnic homogeneity of each early Asian immigrant community. For example, according to a study of New York's Chinatown in the 1890s, "The entire triangular space bounded by Mott, Pell, and Doyers Streets and Chatham Square is given to the exclusive occupancy of these Orientals" (cited in Yuan 1966: 323). Within these enclaves, diversity among Asian nationalities was more salient than commonality.

Economic and residential barriers began to crumble after World War II. The war against Nazism called attention to racism at home and discredited the notions of white superiority. The fifteen years after the war was a period of largely positive change as civil rights statutes outlawed racial discrimination in employment as well as housing (Daniels 1988: ch. 7). Popular attitudes were also changing. Polls taken during World War II showed a distinct hostility toward Japan: 74 percent of the respondents favored either killing off all Japanese, destroying Japan as a political entity, or supervising it. On the

West Coast, 97 percent of the people polled approved of the relocation of Japanese Americans. In contrast, by 1949, 64 percent of those polled were either friendly or neutral toward Japan (Feraru 1950).

During the postwar years, Asian American residential patterns changed significantly. Because of the lack of statistical data,⁴ a longitudinal study of the changing residential patterns of Asian Americans cannot be made. However, descriptive accounts of Asian American communities indicate that these enclaves declined in the postwar years. Edwin Hoyt (1974: 94) reported that in the 1940s, second-generation Chinese Americans moved out of the Chinatowns. Although they still came back to shop or to see friends, they lived elsewhere. In 1940, Rose Hum Lee found twenty-eight cities with an area called Chinatown in the United States. By 1955, Peter Sih found only sixteen (Sung 1967: 143–144). New York's Chinatown exemplifies the declining significance of Asian ethnic enclaves. In 1940, 50 percent of the Chinese in New York City lived in its Chinatown; by 1960, less than one-third lived there (Yuan 1966: 331). Similarly, many returning Japanese Americans abandoned their prewar settlement in old central cities and joined the migration to suburbia (Daniels 1988: 294). In the early 1970s, Little Tokyo in Los Angeles remained a bustling Japanese American center, "but at night the shop owners [went] home to the houses in the suburbs" (Hoyt 1974: 84).

Although single-ethnic communities were still the norm, residential segregation between Asian nationalities declined in the postwar years. Formerly homogeneous, the ethnic enclaves started to house other Asian groups—as well as non-Asian groups. In 1957, driving past 7th and H streets in Washington, D.C., Betty Lee Sung (1967: 142–143) reported, "I passed the length of Chinatown before I suddenly realized that the place was almost deserted. The faces that I did see on the street were not Chinese but Filipinos." In 1970, due to the influx of Japanese and Filipinos, there was a proposal to rename Oakland Chinatown "Asiantown" (Sano 1970). Multigroup urban centers also emerged. Paul Wong (1972: 34) reported that since the early 1960s, Asian Americans of diverse national origins have moved into the suburbs outside the major Asian communities such as Berkeley or San Mateo, California. Although a small proportion of the local population, these Asian Americans tended to congregate in pockets; consequently, in some residential blocks a majority of the residents were Asian Americans.

TABLE 2.2

Mean Segregation Indices for Chinese and Japanese Americans in 822 U.S. Suburbs, 1960, 1970, and 1980

<i>Ethnic Groups</i>	<i>1960</i>	<i>1970</i>	<i>1980</i>	<i>Change, 1960–80</i>
Chinese–White	38.83	31.45	28.22	–10.61
Chinese–Black	54.02	50.42	49.43	–4.59
Japanese–White	34.00	22.16	26.77	–7.23
Japanese–Black	48.62	48.46	45.97	–2.65
Chinese–Japanese	39.11	27.70	24.97	–14.14

Source Lam (1986: tables 1, 2, and 3)

Moreover, recent research on suburban segregation indicates that the level of segregation between certain Asian American groups is often less than that between them and non-Asians. Using Standard Metropolitan Statistical Area (SMSA) data⁵ for 1960, 1970, and 1980, Frankie Lam (1986) computed indices of dissimilarity (ID)⁶ among Chinese, Japanese, black, and white Americans in 822 suburbs. As indicated in Table 2.2, from 1960 to 1980 the level of segregation between Chinese and Japanese Americans was much less than that between these two groups and blacks and, in one case, less than that between these groups and whites. But the actual level of segregation is only one issue. The decline of segregation over time is another. From 1960 to 1980, Chinese segregation from the Japanese shows a more pronounced decline (–14.14) than that of Chinese or Japanese from whites (–10.61 and –7.23 respectively) and from blacks (–4.59 and –2.65 respectively).⁷ Though not comprehensive, these studies together suggest that Asian residential segregation declined in the postwar years.

As various Asian groups in the United States interacted, they became aware of common problems and goals that transcended parochial interests and historical antagonisms. One recurrent problem was employment discrimination. According to a 1965 report published by the California Fair Employment Practices Commission, for every \$51 earned by a white male Californian, Japanese males

earned \$43 and Chinese males \$38—even though Chinese and Japanese American men had become slightly better educated than the white majority (Daniels 1988: 315). Moreover, although the postwar period marked the first time that well-trained Chinese and Japanese Americans could find suitable employment with relative ease, they continued to be passed over for promotion to administrative and supervisory positions (Kitano and Daniels 1988: 47). Asians in the United States began to see themselves as a group that shared important common experiences: exploitation, oppression, and discrimination (Uyematsu 1971).

Because inter-Asian contact and communication were greatest on college campuses, pan-Asianism was strongest there (P. Wong 1972: 33–34). Exposure to one another and to the mainstream society led some young Asian Americans to feel that they were fundamentally different from whites. Disillusioned with the white society and alienated from their traditional communities, many Asian American student activists turned to the alternative strategy of pan-Asian unification (Weiss 1974: 69–70).

The Construction of Pan-Asian Ethnicity

Although broader social struggles and internal demographic changes provided the impetus for the Asian American movement, it was the group's politics—confrontational and explicitly pan-Asian—that shaped the movement's content. Influenced by the internal colonial model, which stresses the commonalities among "colonized groups," college students of Asian ancestry declared solidarity with fellow Asian Americans—and with other Third World⁸ minorities (Blauner 1972: ch. 2). Rejecting the label "Oriental," they proclaimed themselves "Asian American." Through pan-Asian organizations, publications, and Asian American studies programs, Asian American activists built pan-Asian solidarity by pointing out their common fate in American society. The pan-Asian concept enabled diverse Asian American groups to understand their "unequal circumstances and histories as being related" (Lowe 1991: 30).

From "Yellow" to "Asian American"

Following the example of the Black Power movement, Asian American activists spearheaded their own Yellow Power movement to seek "freedom from racial oppression through the power of a consolidated yellow people" (Uyematsu 1971: 12). In the summer of 1968, more than one hundred students of diverse Asian backgrounds attended an "Are You Yellow?" conference at UCLA to discuss issues of Yellow Power, identity, and the war in Vietnam (Ling 1989: 53). In 1970, a new pan-Asian organization in northern California called itself the "Yellow Seed" because "Yellow [is] the common bond between Asian-Americans and Seed symboliz[es] growth as an individual and as an alliance" (Masada 1970). This "yellow" reference was dropped when Filipino Americans rejected the term, claiming that they were brown, not yellow (Rabaya 1971: 110; Ignacio 1976: 84). At the first Asian American national conference in 1972, Filipino Americans "made it clear to the conferees that we were 'Brown Asians'" by forming a Brown Asian Caucus (Ignacio 1976: 139-141). It is important to note, however, that Filipino American activists did not reject the term "yellow" because they objected to the pan-Asian framework. Quite the contrary, they rejected it because it allegedly excluded them from that grouping (Rabaya 1971: 110).

Other community organizers used the term "Oriental" to define their organizations and service centers. In Southern California, the Council of Oriental Organizations (COO) became the political base for the diverse Asian American communities. In 1968, COO lobbied for federal funding to establish the Oriental Service Center in Los Angeles County, serving Chinese, Japanese, Filipinos, and Koreans. But Asian American activists also rejected *Oriental* because the term conjures up images of "the sexy Susie Wong, the wily Charlie Chan, and the evil Fu Manchu" (Weiss 1974: 234). It is also a term that smacks of European colonialism and imperialism: *Oriental* means "East"; Asia is "east" only in relationship to Europe, which was taken as the point of reference (Browne 1985). To define their own image and to claim an *American* identity, college students of Asian ancestry coined the term *Asian American* to "stand for all of us Americans of Asian descent" (Ichioka interview). While *Oriental* suggests passivity and acquiescence, *Asian Americans* connotes political activism because an Asian American "gives a damn about his life, his work, his

beliefs, and is willing to do almost anything to help Orientals become Asian Americans" (cited in Weiss 1974: 234).

The account above suggests that the creation of a new name is a significant symbolic move in constructing an ethnic identity. In their attempt to forge a pan-Asian identity, Asian American activists first had to coin a composite term that would unify and encompass the constituent groups. Filipino Americans' rejection of the term "yellow" and the activists' objection to the cliché-ridden *Oriental* forced the group to change its name to Asian American. The history of the Sansei Concern, a UCLA student group, provides a telling example. In the summer of 1968, as we have seen, Sansei Concern organized the "Are You Yellow?" conference. At the end of the conference, in an effort to incorporate other Asian subgroups, Sansei Concern changed its name to Oriental Concern. In 1969, reflecting its growing political sophistication, the group changed its name once more to Asian American Political Alliance, a name adopted by a group of activists at the University of California at Berkeley the year before (Ling 1989: 53). It is noteworthy that while *Yellow*, *Oriental*, and *Asian American* connote different ideologies, all three terms signify panethnicity.

Pan-Asian Organizations

Influenced by the political tempo of the 1960s, young Asian Americans began to join such organizations as the Free Speech Movement at the University of California at Berkeley, Students for a Democratic Society, and the Progressive Labor Party. However, these young activists "had no organization or coalition to draw attention to themselves as a distinct group" (P. Wong 1972: 33). Instead, they participated as individuals—often at the invitation of their white or black friends (Chin 1971b: 285; Nakano 1984: 3–4). While Asian American activists subscribed to the integrationist ideology of the 1960s and 1970s social movements, they also felt impotent and alienated. There was no structure to uphold their own identity. As an example, when the Peace and Freedom Party was formed on the basis of black and white coalitions, Asian American activists felt excluded because they were neither black nor white (P. Wong 1972: 34; Yoshimura 1989: 107).

In the late 1960s, linking their political views with the growth of racial pride among their ranks, Asian Americans already active in various political movements came together to form their own organizations (Nakano 1984: 3–4). Most of the early pan-Asian organizations were college based. In 1968, activists at the University of California, Berkeley founded one of the first pan-Asian political organizations: the Asian American Political Alliance (AAPA). According to a co-founder of the organization, its establishment marked the first time that the term “Asian American” was used nationally to mobilize people of Asian descent (Ichioka interview). AAPA was formed to increase the political visibility and effectiveness of Asian American activists:

There were so many Asians out there in the political demonstrations but we had no effectiveness. Everyone was lost in the larger rally. We figured that if we rallied behind our own banner, behind an Asian American banner, we would have an effect on the larger public. We could extend the influence beyond ourselves, to other Asian Americans. (Ichioka interview)

AAPA differed from the traditional Asian cultural groups on most college campuses in two primary ways: its political activism and its pan-Asian emphasis. Reflecting the various political movements from which its members had come, AAPA took progressive stands against the war in Vietnam and in support of other Third World movements (Ichioka interview). Espousing a pan-Asian framework, AAPA brought together young Chinese, Japanese, and Filipino American activists (Nishio 1982: 37).⁹ Shortly after AAPA was formed at the University of California at Berkeley, a sister organization was established at San Francisco State College (now University). Like its Berkeley counterpart, San Francisco State AAPA “was a vehicle for students to share political concerns in a pan-Asian organization” (Umemoto 1989: 17). AAPA’s influence also spread to Southern California as Asian American students formed similar organizations on the UCLA and California State University, Long Beach campuses (Ling 1984; Yoshimura 1989).

Pan-Asian organizations also mushroomed in other parts of the country. In 1969, through the initiative of West Coast students, Asian American organizations began to form on East Coast campuses. For example, in New York, young Asian Americans organized Asian

Americans for Action, or Triple A. At Columbia University, Asian Americans involved in white radical politics came together to found their own Asian American Political Alliance. Students at Yale prepared and taught a course on "Asians in America" (Chin 1971b: 285). Similarly, in the Midwest, the civil rights, antiwar, and United Farm Workers movements drew Asian Americans together. Out of these political gatherings emerged a group of Asian American activists who subsequently formed Madison's Asian Union, Illinois' Asian American Alliance, and Minneapolis' Asian American Political Alliance (Rice Paper 1975).

Not only did pan-Asian organizations reinforce the cohesiveness of already existing networks, but they also expanded these networks. By the mid-1970s, *Asian American* had become a familiar term (Lott 1976: 30). Although first coined by college activists, the pan-Asian concept began to be used extensively by professional and community spokespersons to lobby for the health and welfare of Americans of Asian descent. In addition to the local and single-ethnic organizations of an earlier era, Asian American professionals and community activists formed national and pan-Asian organizations such as the Pacific/Asian Coalition and the Asian American Social Workers (Ignacio 1976: 162; Kuo 1979: 283–284). Also, Asian American caucuses could be found in national professional organizations such as the American Public Health Association, the American Sociological Association, the American Psychological Association, the American Psychiatric Association, and the American Librarians Association (Lott 1976: 31). Commenting on the "literally scores of pan-Asian organizations" in the mid-1970s, William Liu (1976: 6) asserted that "the idea of pan-Asian cooperation [was] viable and ripe for development."

Asian American Studies

On college and university campuses, the most important legacy of the Asian American movement was the institutionalization of Asian American studies.¹⁰ Beginning in 1968, under the slogan of self-determination, Asian American and other U.S. Third World students fought for an education more relevant and accessible to their communities. Reflecting the larger national struggle over cultural hegemony, these students demanded the right to control their

educational agenda, to design their own programs, and to evaluate their instructors (Umemoto 1989: 3–4). In 1968, after the most prolonged and violent campus struggles in this country's history, Asian American studies programs were established at San Francisco State College (now University) and at the University of California at Berkeley. These campus struggles emboldened students at other colleges to fight for ethnic studies courses, programs, and departments and forced college administrations to heed such demands (Murase 1976a: 205–209). In succeeding years, Asian American Studies programs were established on major campuses throughout the country.¹¹ Since 1968, the field has progressed from experimental courses to degree programs. For example, UC Berkeley and UCLA now offer B.A. and M.A. degree programs in Asian American Studies respectively (Nakanishi and Leong 1978: 6).

Although varied in their curriculum development and course offerings, Asian American Studies programs built, and continue to build, an Asian American heritage, putting courses and reading selections together and expounding similarities—as well as differences—in the experiences of Asian peoples in the United States. Indeed, the curriculum was designed to help students “know who they are as Asian Americans” (Contemporary Asian Studies Division 1973: 38). Clearly part of the heritage being created hinges on Asian Americans' shared history of racial discrimination. Many courses stress an Asian American identity and experience, yielding highly emotional discussions on subjects dealing with discrimination, alienation, and racism (Weiss 1974: 241). Such an emphasis is evident in the following statement of curriculum philosophy for Asian American Studies:

Throughout much of America's history, Asians in this country have been the victims of contempt and exploitation. Often they were singled out as scapegoats in periods of severe economic depression, such as the nation-wide anti-Chinese agitations and riots in the 1870's and 1880's, and Asian Americans were regarded as enemies during times of international conflicts, particularly the Second World War and the Korean War. (Contemporary Asian Studies Division 1973: 35)

This statement links together the experiences of Chinese, Japanese, and Korean Americans; in so doing, it calls attention to their collective identity.

TABLE 2.3

Percentage of Studies on Specific Asian Groups for Bibliographies and Publications Released during the 1970s and 1980s

<i>Ethnic Group</i>	<i>Total Number</i>	<i>Percentage of Total Studies for Century</i>	<i>Percentage Published 1970s–80s</i>
Asian	208	15	37
Chinese	460	33	23
East Indian	53	4	17
Filipino	96	7	26
Japanese	514	37	18
Korean	32	2	75
Pacific Islander	8	0.6	75
Southeast Asian	6	0.4	83

Source: Asians in America (1983: vii).

Also, Asian American scholars began to reinterpret Asian history in the United States to bring out what is common to all Asian Americans. These histories highlight a record of violence against Asians, who were denied the rights of citizenship, forbidden to own land, interned in relocation camps, and forced to live in poverty-stricken enclaves (Jensen and Abeyta 1987: 406). For example, in discussing discriminatory laws and informal acts perpetrated against Chinese, Korean, Filipino, and Japanese immigrants, Lowell Chun-Hoon (1975: 47) concluded that “what is significant [about this exploitation] is that all of these varied Asian groups, each representing a separate country and unique culture, encountered a similar or identical pattern of racial oppression and economic exploitation.” Also, Asian Americans were treated increasingly as a single unit of analysis in academic studies. A survey of studies on Asian groups in the United States indicates that works dealing with “Asians” increased dramatically during the 1970s and 1980s (see Table 2.3). Articles published in these decades represent 37 percent of such articles published in this country, “almost three times as many works” as might have been expected (*Asians in America* 1983: viii).

Along the same lines, in addition to explaining specific group experiences, Asian American writers have turned their attention to those experiences shared by the various Asian peoples. In the 1971 publication *Roots: An Asian American Reader*, the autobiographies and poems that appear in the "Identity" section "express the increasing commitment of Asian Americans to redefine and articulate their individual and collective identity. While they reflect a wide range of backgrounds and responses to American society, there can be found a common level of experience with which all Asians in America can identify" (Tachiki 1971: 4). This new direction enlarged the context of Asian American writing, and led to the use of the term "Asian American literature" (E. Kim 1982). As Jesse Hiraoka (1986: 95) stated, the overriding objective "became that of establishing an Asian American heritage in terms of the arrival and stay of the Asians in the United States, and the changes that occurred as they consolidated their presence in American society."

In sum, Asian American Studies provides an institutional means to reach more Asian American students and to create "an Asian American awareness expressing a unity of all Asians, Chinese, Japanese, Filipino, Korean, Samoan, and Hawaiian" (E. Wong 1971: 248). Its by-products—the Association for Asian American Studies, national conferences, research centers, and publications—further stimulate pan-Asian solidarity because they provide a forum for Asian Americans to discuss common problems and experiences.¹² In these settings, "the experiences of different Asian groups were compared and recognized as historically intertwined" (Ling 1989: 73).

Asian American News Media

The 1960s and 1970s also saw the rapid growth of a pan-Asian news medium directed toward the largest possible Asian audience, covering both ethnic and panethnic developments and concerns (see Table 2.4). Ethnic publications are important because they promote ethnic ideology and keep alive ethnic symbols and values, heroes, and historical achievements. It is the very business of the ethnic media to be concerned with the events and progress of the ethnic group (Breton 1964: 201). Until the late 1960s, most of the Asian newspapers and periodicals were concerned primarily with local and single-ethnic issues.

TABLE 2.4***Partial Listing of Asian American Periodicals, Late 1960s–Early 1970s***

<i>Publication</i>	<i>Place of Publication</i>
AACTION	Philadelphia, Pa
AASA	California State University at Northridge
AASA	Cornell University, Ithaca, N.Y.
Aion	San Francisco
<i>Amerasia Journal</i>	Yale University, New Haven, Conn. (now UCLA)
<i>Ameri-Asia News</i>	Forest City, Fla.
<i>Asian American for Equal Employment Newspaper</i>	New York City
<i>Asian Expression</i>	California State University at Dominguez Hills
<i>Asian Family Affair</i>	Seattle, Wash.
<i>Asian Spotlight</i>	College of San Mateo, Calif.
<i>Asian Student, The</i>	Berkeley, Calif.
<i>Asian Student</i>	City College of New York
<i>Asian Student Voice</i>	San Francisco State
<i>Bridge: An Asian American Perspective</i>	New York City
<i>Crosscurrents</i>	Los Angeles
<i>East Wind</i>	Los Angeles
<i>Eastern Wind</i>	Washington, D.C.
<i>Getting Together</i>	New York City Chinatown
<i>Gidra</i>	Los Angeles
<i>Jade: The Asian American Magazine</i>	Los Angeles
<i>Pacific Ties</i>	Los Angeles
<i>Rice Paper</i>	Madison, Wis.
<i>Rodan</i>	San Francisco

Source. Compiled by author.

Pan-Asian periodicals came out of the Asian American movement, the efforts of Asian American student organizations on university campuses across the country. In fact, "these newspapers, pamphlets, and magazines were the lifeblood of the movement" (Quinsaat 1976: 267). While the traditional ethnic press continued to be important, its neglect and disdain of such political issues as civil rights, the Vietnam war, and ethnic studies prompted young dissidents to launch their own publications. Much of their journalism was committed to the empowerment of the Asian American people.

Although not always successful, some publications attempted to formulate a pan-Asian perspective rather than any singular ethnic outlook (Quinsaat 1976). In 1969, five UCLA students put up \$100 each to launch the monthly publication *Gidra*, the first and most widely circulated pan-Asian publication. In all, during its five years of publication, about two hundred individuals participated in producing *Gidra* (Murase 1976b). On the East Coast, *Getting Together*, a New York Chinatown newspaper, expounded Asian American issues from a militant orientation; its stated purpose was to "further advance the just causes of Asian people in this country" (Chin 1971a: 30; *Getting Together* 1972: 1). These movement periodicals covered both ethnic and panethnic concerns. For example, the first issue of *Getting Together* included the following stories: "Chinatown and Its Problems," "Serving the People," "Yellow Power," and "Concentration Camps in the USA." Emphasizing its Chinese American as well as Asian American identity, the staff of *Getting Together* wrote, "We are not a bunch of 'do-gooders' out to save somebody else; we only know that our freedom and happiness are tied-in with the freedom and happiness of every Chinese and every Asian person" (cited in Chin 1971b: 286). Initiated in 1971 by the Yale Asian American Students Association, *Amerasia Journal* (now housed at UCLA) became the only national scholarly publication devoted exclusively to the study of the experience of Asians in America.

Besides functioning as a source of news for young Asian American activists, these media efforts also forged pan-Asian consciousness. Through articles, poetry, and photographs in a variety of publications, and by meeting together, these young Asian Americans across the country began to communicate with one another and to share their frustrations and their dreams. From these efforts, they began "to formulate their own values, establish their own identities and

sense of pride, and create a new 'culture' which they can truly call Asian American" (Chin 1971a: 29). In the final issue of *Gidra*, Mike Murase (1976b: 319) described the solidarity that emerged from this collective experience:

It has been an experience in sharing—in giving and receiving—in a sisterly and brotherly atmosphere. It has meant a chance to work for something we really believe in. It has meant a chance to express ourselves in a variety of ways. . . . It has meant working with people who care about people, and genuinely feeling the strength that can only come out of collective experience.¹³

By the mid-1970s, due to inadequate manpower and funding, many of the movement publications had folded. In their place came slicker and more business-minded publications. The transition from radical to "bourgeois" journalism reflects broader changes in pan-Asian political consciousness in the last two decades—from the confrontational to the more orthodox. For example, founded in the late 1980s, both *Rice* and *AsiAm* were nationally distributed magazines geared toward young and upper-income Asian American professionals.¹⁴ Among the pan-Asian newspapers, *Asian Week*, published in San Francisco since 1979, has been the most stable. According to the weekly's managing editor, the management team decided to name the newspaper *Asian Week* instead of the proposed *Chinese Week* to "reflect the widespread acceptance of the pan-Asian concept" (Anderesen interview). In recent years, some single-ethnic newspapers have also broadened their scope to cover additional Asian communities. For example, in the mid-1980s, *East/West* dropped its subtitle "A Chinese American Newspaper" and devoted more space to national Asian American issues. A content analysis of the longstanding Japanese American publication *Pacific Citizen* indicates that, from 1955 to 1985, the newspaper became more pan-Asian. As Table 2.5 indicates, the surge in Asian articles coincided with the Asian American movement of the late 1960s.

Although varied in their successes, these pan-Asian journals testify to the salience of a generalized Asian American readership. They are also important because they bring the news of the entire Asian American population to the various Asian American subgroups. In so doing, they enlarge the scope of Asian American awareness and dialogue beyond the boundaries of province and nationality.

TABLE 2.5

*Number of Pacific Citizen Articles Covering Asian Stories,
April, August, and December 1955–85*

<i>Year</i>	<i>April</i>	<i>August</i>	<i>December</i>	<i>Total</i>
1955	0	0	1	1
1960	0	0	0	0
1965	1	0	0	1
1970	12	5	8	25
1975	2	2	1	5
1980	4	4	4	12
1985	12	5	7	24

Source: Compiled by author from *Pacific Citizen*, 1955–85. An Asian story is defined as one that covers a non-Japanese Asian group or one that covers all Asian groups. Only the first issue of each month was examined.

An Asian American Perspective: In Quest of Identity

Although an offshoot of the mass struggles of the late 1960s, the Asian American movement was not only a political movement but one that emphasized “race,” as that term is conventionally understood. Like their non-Asian peers of the time, young Asian American activists joined in the struggles against poverty, war, and exploitation. However, they often viewed these struggles from an Asian American perspective, emphasizing race and racism directed against Asian Americans. This racial perspective bound them to other Asian groups as well as to other minorities, while separating them from whites. The importance of race (or racial ideology) is most evident in Asian American participation in and interpretation of the antiwar, New Left, and women’s movements.

Antiwar Movement

The antiwar movement united Asian Americans along racial lines. For many Asian American activists, the American invasion of Vietnam involved more than the issues of national sovereignty or

imperialism; it also raised questions of racism directed against Asian people (Kwong 1987: 148). Watching the images of war on the evening television news, "an increasing number of Asian American college and high school students realized with a shock that the 'enemy' whom American soldiers were maiming and killing had faces like their own" (Chan 1991: 174). Seeing unarmed, unresisting civilians napalmed in Vietnam angered young Asian Americans and stirred them to protest the prevailing assumption that Asian lives were cheap. To emphasize the racist nature of the war, Asian American protesters discarded the popular slogans "Give peace a chance" and "Bring the GIs home," and touted their own "Stop killing our Asian brothers and sisters" and "We don't want your racist war" (P. Wong 1972: 35–36). According to Asian American antiwar activists, the slogan "Bring our boys home" clearly proclaimed that the primary concern was to avoid American, not Vietnamese, casualties (*Bridge* 1973: 3).

As Asian people fighting in an Asian country, Asian American G.I.s were particularly repulsed by the atrocities committed against the Vietnamese people:

For some G.I.'s in Vietnam, there are no Vietnamese people. To them the land is not populated by people but by "Gooks," considered inferior, unhuman animals by the racist-educated G.I. Relieved in his mind of human responsibility by this grotesque stereotype, numerous barbarities have been committed against these Asian peoples, since "they're only 'Gooks.'" (Nakamura 1971: 24)

Because of their racial similarity to the "enemy," Asian American G.I.s also endured anti-Asian racism. Many Asian Americans complained that their superior officers and fellow G.I.s lumped them together with other Asian groups: regardless of their ethnic background, Asian American soldiers were indiscriminately called Gook, Jap, Chink, or Ho Chi Minh. An Asian American G.I. related that, upon entering basic training, he was called a "Gook" and was made to stand in front of his platoon as an example of "what the enemy looked like" (Yoshimura 1971). The "Gook" stereotype "portrays Koreans, Vietnamese, Cambodians, Laotians, and other Asians as subhuman beings who do not value individual human life and who all look like the treacherous Chinese Communist enemy" (Tachiki 1971: 2–3).

The stereotype angered and ethnicized Asian American G.I.s. As a former American G.I. of Japanese ancestry related, "I became ethnicized when I was in Vietnam. I saw how whites were treating the Vietnamese, calling them Gooks, running them over with their trucks. I figured I am a Gook also" (Watanabe interview).

At times, the race question alienated Asian Americans from the majority of the antiwar protesters. An Asian American activist recounted the tension in the antiwar camp:

In the early stage, there was a debate on what would be the main slogan. One slogan was "Bring the GIs home." The white component felt that this would unite the greatest amount of concern. But the Asian community felt that this slogan ignored what the U.S. was doing over there in Asia. Asian Americans were the only group that pushed the question of racism toward Asians. They wanted to know why the U.S. was involved in Asia in World War II and in Vietnam now. (Omatsu interview)

In 1971, the Asian American contingent refused to join the main antiwar march in Washington, D.C. because the coordinating committee failed to adopt the contingent's antiracist statement for the march. On other occasions, the contingent's appeals "were met with hostility and rejection" (P. Wong 1972: 34–36). When Asian Americans did take part in the white-dominated marches, they passed out their own leaflets, which denounced racism and imperialism. A Japanese American antiwar protester described the Asian flavor of the Asian American contingent:

I marched in the April 24 [antiwar] demonstration in San Francisco with the Asian contingent. That was everybody: Filipinos, Chinese, Koreans, and Japanese. We marched together, waving red books and carried the People's Chinese flag, a Pathet Lao flag, some North Korean flags, Vietnamese flags, and a Chinese flag—and it was good. (Sumi 1971: 259)

In sum, Asian American emphasis on race and racism differentiates their antiwar protest from that of whites. In characterizing the Vietnam war as a racist act against Asians, Asian American activists proclaimed racial solidarity not only with each other but also with the Vietnamese people, their "Asian brothers and sisters" (Bridge 1973: 3). In the process, pan-Asian political consciousness became transnationalized, encompassing the political struggles not only in

America but also in Asia. As an Asian American activist stated, "As long as there are U.S. troops in Asia, as long as the U.S. government and the military wage wars of aggression against Asian people, racism against Asians will serve the interest of this country. Racism against them is often racism against us" (Yoshimura 1971: 29).

New Left Movement

In the late 1960s and early 1970s, a significant number of Asian Americans also became active in New Left activities and organizations such as the Free Speech Movement (FSM), Students for a Democratic Society (SDS), the Weathermen, and the Progressive Labor Party. Asian American Marxist organizations grew out of these New Left activities (Nakano 1984: 2–3). Diverging from the Old Left emphasis on the working class as the leading revolutionary stratum, the New Left sought to organize people across class lines. The New Left also looked away from the Soviet Union and to the Vietnamese National Liberation Front and the People's Republic of China as new models of socialism. It was the New Left's version of socialism and the movements growing admiration for Asian countries that influenced the thinking of Asian American Marxists (Liu and Cheng 1986: 144–145).

As in the antiwar movement, the Asian American New Left separated itself from the dominant New Left movement over the issues of racism and national oppression. It was over these questions that Asian American working people acquainted themselves with Marxism—a Marxism that emphasized race as well as class (Liu and Cheng 1986: 148). Influenced by the call for national liberation by the Black Power movement and Asian socialist countries, Asian American Marxists added racial self-determination to their revolutionary agenda (Nakano 1984: 4–5). For many Asian American community activists, there was no contradiction between a Marxist–Leninist approach and the prominence given to race. Because race constitutes such a fundamental category in American society, Asian Americans (and other racial minority groups) often view class issues from a racial perspective (Lipsitz 1988: 235). For example, the ethnic consciousness of the Red Guard in San Francisco's Chinatown "usually supersedes and sometimes clashes with their alleged attachment to a class-oriented ideology" (Lyman 1973: 29).¹⁵ The centrality of race is

evident in the following call for Marxist–Leninist organizing in the Asian American communities:

The situation in the Asian communities is so deplorable that a Marxist-Leninist Party must begin to take firm root among the people. It is necessary that this party does not alienate the people or create any factions among the budding Asian American movement as we do not even make up 1% of the total population of America. The purpose of this party is to educate the people on the fact that the Asian communities in America are included in the genocidal American foreign policy in Asia. (Hing 1970: 9–10)

In contrast, other white-dominated groups like the Revolutionary Union (now the Revolutionary Communist Party) considered the national oppression question to be of secondary importance to the “bread and butter” issues that affected all workers (*East Wind* 1979: 111).

Varied in their understanding and application of Marxism, Asian American Marxist organizations struggled over the relative importance of nation building and party building. Despite their desires for revolutionary change and socialism, the issue of national liberation continued to be the guiding principle for many Asian American community groups. This position is evident in the following statement issued by the I Wor Kuen (IWK),¹⁶ the largest revolutionary organization in the Asian American community in the 1970s:

Our organization, like many others in America, arose as a response to national oppression and racial discrimination, and as part of the growing anti-imperialist movement in the 1960s. We formed as an Asian organization because, in 1968–69, the national oppression and corresponding national struggles of Third World peoples was the sharpest in the nationwide progressive movements. Furthermore, the bankruptcy of the Communist Party, USA and Progressive Labor Party, among others, especially in relation to the national question, made joining their ranks out of the question. (I Wor Kuen 1974: 6–7)

The IWK also combined the goal of racial self-determination with the goal of socialism. For example, in 1969, the organization issued a twelve-point program and platform that included demands for self-determination for Asian Americans and Asians as well as the establishment of a socialist party (Liu and Cheng 1986: 147).

In 1972, in an attempt to apply Marxism to the national question, the Marxist-oriented organization East Wind adopted the "Asian nation" line. Echoing the separatist call in the black community, East Wind declared that as a racially oppressed minority, Asian Americans were entitled to form their own nation. Although East Wind dropped the Asian nation line in 1975, it continued to stress the importance of national liberation (Nakano 1984: 10–12). On the other hand, organizations such as the New York-based Asian Study Group advocated party building and criticized other Asian American revolutionary groups for their preoccupation with "band-aid" social service programs (Nakano 1984: 14–17). Many of these differences remained unresolved, eventually dissolving friendships as well as organizations (Ling 1984).

In short, as in the antiwar movement, Asian American Marxists added a racial perspective to the New Left movement. This racial perspective bound them to other Asian Americans as it separated them from other non-Asian components. Just as women in other social movements were identifying barriers that restricted their roles, Asian American women activists began to challenge sexism and introduce gender-related issues into the Asian American movement.

Women's Movement

Although Asian American women had been involved in each stage of the Asian American movement, they were often restricted to such subordinate tasks as taking minutes, typing, making coffee, and answering phones. The small number of Asian American women who achieved leadership positions in the movement found themselves called "bossy" and "unfeminine" (Rodan 1971; Ling 1989: 53). Asian American feminists who challenged Asian American sexism were often cast as betraying Asian American nationalism—as assimilationists (Lowe 1991: 31).

Sexist oppression prevailed even in the most revolutionary Asian American organizations. For example, the San Francisco-based Red Guards initially claimed that women's worth was only in staying at home and in producing children (Nakano 1984: 13). Along the same lines, the Marxist-oriented I Wor Kuen championed forsaking monogamy to liberate relations between men and women and to build collective solidarity. In actuality, this sexual liberation was "a cover

for degeneracy and the most blatant forms of male supremacy and the oppression of women" (cited in Nakano 1984: 13). Rebelling against the sexual oppression of women in the Asian American movement, an angry Asian American poet wrote:

so you come to me for a spiritual piece
my eyes have the ol' epicanthic fold
my skin is the ideologically correct color
a legit lay for the revolutionary
well, let me tell you, brother
revolution must be total
and you're in its way
yeah, yeah, I'm all sympathy
your soul and your sexuality has
been fucked over by Amerika
well, so has mine
so has ours
we chronic smilers
asian women
we of the downcast almond eyes
are seeing each other
sisters now, people now
asian women. (T. Tanaka 1971)

Frustrated with male chauvinism, Asian American women began meeting separately from men to discuss feminist concerns. Their collective anger was nurtured by the progressive ideology of the women's movement of the late 1960s. Although they borrowed heavily from the general women's movement, Asian American women seldom joined these middle-class, white-dominated organizations. Like black, Chicana, and Native American women, Asian American women felt alienated and at times exploited by these women's organizations.

In its early development, the women's movement was in fact insensitive to the issues of minority and lower-class women (Ling 1989). In contrast, Asian American and other Third World feminists emphasized the "triple oppression" concept: their gender was inextricably linked to their race and class. As an Asian women's studies instructor reflected, "The writings of white middle-class women on 'women's lib' . . . failed to speak relevantly to Asian American women. Many Asian women faced discrimination not only as

women, but also on the basis of race, cultural background or low socio-economic status" (Chen 1976: 235). In the provocative "Yellow Prostitution," an Asian American feminist chastised Asian women who tried to be white:

It is not enough that we must "kow tow" to the Yellow male ego, but we must do this by aping the Madison Avenue and Hollywood version of *White* femininity. All the peroxide, foam rubber, and scotch tape will not transform you into what you are not. . . . Whether this is a conditioned desire to be white, or a desperate attempt to attain male approval, it is nothing more than Yellow Prostitution. (Gil 1968)

Because "their ethnic identity was a critical component of their feminism" (Ling 1989: 52), Asian American feminists refused to advocate a non-Asian alliance—despite the fact that white feminists could offer important resources and shared similar concerns. Distancing themselves from the general feminist movement, Asian American women organized their own movement. For Asian American women activists, the ideology of feminism had to be incorporated into the larger identity of being Asian American. According to Susie Ling (1989: 63), "The Asian Women's Movement's umbilical cord was still very much attached to the larger Asian American Movement." Asian American women chose two major paths of activism: they worked within the Asian American community or within Marxist–Leninist groups. In 1971, Asian American women in Los Angeles organized Asian Sisters to address the drug problems of young Asian American women. It was one of the first social service projects for Asian American women by Asian American women. In 1972, they established Little Friends Playground to provide childcare for the community (Ling 1989). The Marxist–Leninist groups that Asian American women were involved in remain Asian American–oriented today (Ling 1984: 209). Asian American women were also concerned with the social conditions of their Asian sisters in China and Vietnam. For example, in 1971, the Los Angeles Asian women's movement sent delegates to the Vancouver Indochinese Women's Conference to express their solidarity with these women (Ling 1989: 55).

The Limits of Pan-Asianism

Although pan-Asian consolidation certainly has occurred, it has been by no means universal. For those who wanted a broader political agenda, the pan-Asian scope was too narrow and its racial orientation too segregative (P. Wong 1972: 33; Lowe 1991: 39). For others who wanted to preserve ethnic particularism, the pan-Asian agenda threatened to remove second- and third-generation Asians "from their conceptual ties to their community" (R. Tanaka 1976: 47). These competing levels of organization mitigated the impact of pan-Asianism.

Moreover, pan-Asianism has been primarily the ideology of native-born, American-educated, and middle-class Asians. Embraced by students, artists, professionals, and political activists, pan-Asian consciousness thrived on college campuses and in urban settings. However, it barely touched the Asian ethnic enclaves. When the middle-class student activists carried the enlarged and politicized Asian American consciousness to the ethnic communities, they encountered apprehension, if not outright hostility (Chan 1991: 175). Conscious of their national origins and overburdened with their day-to-day struggles for survival, most community residents ignored or spurned the movement's political agenda (P. Wong 1972: 34). Chin (1971b: 287) reported that few Chinatown residents participated in any of the pan-Asian political events. Similarly, members of the Nisei-dominated Japanese American Citizens League "were determined to keep a closed mind and maintain their negative stereotype" of the members of the Asian American Political Alliance (J. Matsui 1968: 6). For their part, young Asian American activists accused their elders of having been so whitewashed that they had deleted their experiences of prejudice and discrimination from their history (Weiss 1974: 238). Because these young activists were not rooted in the community, their base of support was narrow and their impact upon the larger society often limited (P. Wong 1972: 37; Nishio 1982: 37).

Even among those who were involved in the Asian American movement, divisions arose from conflicting sets of interests as subgroups decided what and whose interests would be addressed. Often-times, conflicts over material interests took on ethnic coloration, with participants from smaller subgroups charging that "Asian American" primarily meant Chinese and Japanese American, the

TABLE 2.6

*Asian American Studies Instructors in the United States
by Ethnic Group, 1973*

<i>Ethnic Group</i>	<i>Total</i>	<i>Doctorate</i>	<i>Master's</i>	<i>Bachelor's or less</i>	<i>Don't Know</i>
Chinese	27	1	10	12	4
Filipino	9	1	1	4	3
Japanese	33	6	14	6	7
Korean	3	1	1	1	0
White	5	4	0	0	1
Don't Know	5	0	1	0	4

Source. Chun-Hoon, Hirata, and Moriyama (1973: 85) Chun-Hoon, Hirata, and Moriyama (1973) sent about twenty-five questionnaires to select institutions across the country. The table is based on the eight responses received

two largest and most acculturated Asian American groups at the time (Ignacio 1976: 220; Ling 1984: 193–195). For example, most Asian American Studies programs did not include courses on other Asian groups, but only on Chinese and Japanese. Similarly, the Asian American women's movement often subsumed the needs of their Korean and Filipina members under those of Chinese and Japanese women (Ling 1984: 193–195). Chinese and Japanese Americans also were the instructors of Asian American ethnic studies (see Table 2.6), directors and staff members of many Asian American projects,¹⁷ and advisory and panel members in many governmental agencies (Ignacio 1976: 223–224).

The ethnic and class inequality within the pan-Asian structure has continued to be a source of friction and mistrust, with participants from the less dominant groups feeling shortchanged and excluded. As discussed in subsequent chapters, the influx of the post-1965 immigrants and the tightening of public funding resources have further deepened the ethnic and class cleavages among Asian American subgroups.

Conclusion

The development of a pan-Asian consciousness and constituency reflected broader societal developments and demographic changes, as well as the group's political agenda. By the late 1960s, pan-Asianism was possible because of the more amicable relationships among the Asian countries, the declining residential segregation among diverse Asian groups in America, and the large number of native-born, American-educated political actors. Disillusioned with the larger society and estranged from their traditional communities, third- and fourth-generation Asian Americans turned to the alternative strategy of pan-Asian unification. Through pan-Asian organizations, media, and Asian American Studies programs, these political activists assumed the role of "cultural entrepreneurs" consciously creating a community of culture out of diverse Asian peoples.¹⁸ This process of pan-Asian consolidation did not proceed smoothly nor did it encompass all Asian Americans. Ethnic chauvinism, competition for scarce resources, and class cleavages continued to divide the subgroups. However, once established, the pan-Asian structure not only reinforced the cohesiveness of already existing networks but also expanded these networks. As later chapters indicate, although first conceived by young Asian American activists, the pan-Asian concept was subsequently institutionalized by professionals and community groups, as well as government agencies. The confrontational politics of the activists eventually gave way to the conventional and electoral politics of the politicians, lobbyists, and professionals, as Asian Americans continued to rely on the pan-Asian framework to enlarge their political capacities.